

Project 14

Course Code and Name: MSJ4142 Public Relations Campaign

Project Name: Case Analysis of a PR Campaign by Rolls Royce's

Project Type: Case analysis

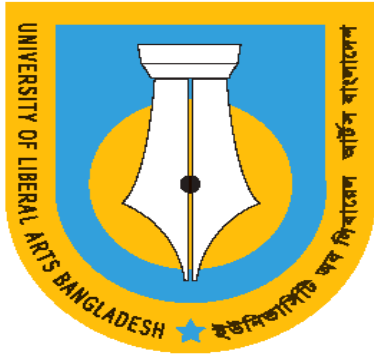
Semester of Submission: Spring 2025

Project Description:

This project analyzes Rolls-Royce's 2016 Black Badge PR campaign, which repositioned the brand to appeal to younger, modern luxury consumers. It examines the campaign's objectives, target audience, SWOT analysis, messaging, communication channels, creative tactics, and outcomes.

Project Justification:

The project explores how Rolls-Royce modernized its heritage image while preserving its core identity and attracting younger consumers. The Black Badge campaign shows how PR, storytelling, digital media, experiential marketing, and influencers can make a luxury brand more relevant to a new generation.



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MSJ 4141: PR campaign

Case Analysis

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Case Analysis of a PR Campaign by
Rolls Royce's
“Black Badge: Rules Rewritten”

For the 2016 launch of the Black Badge series, Rolls Royce developed a renowned PR campaign aimed at changing the way modern luxury consumers' view their brand. Black Badge is an innovative car brand that Rolls Royce created to appeal to the future generation of luxury buyers, which now primarily consists of independent business owners and creative workers. The marketing plan tackled both the development of modern, wealthy clients and the destruction of the traditional, conservative Rolls Royce image. By utilizing immersive visuals, digital media tactics, influencer interaction, and strong storytelling components, the brand was able to connect with younger consumers and uphold its reputation as a premium craftsmanship brand.

Campaign Background

Rolls Royce introduced the Black Badge campaign in March 2016 to redefine its brand through marketing towards self-made-risk-taking individuals in a new customer demographic. Rolls Royce strived to win younger individuals who avoided its traditional status for older elites and royalty yet wanted to preserve their luxury element.

Objectives

1. Rolls Royce needs to eliminate the outdated public perception that their cars symbolize old fashioned formal style.
2. The company should launch a sub-brand with dark a luxury design which specifically targets contemporary innovative customers.
3. The Black Badge Wraith and Ghost models must become popular throughout their market segment.

4. Rolls-Royce should establish new business sections that attract technology startup founders together with creative people and individuals from the millennial high income demographic.

Target Audience and Market Analysis

1. The target market consists of consumers between 28 to 45 years old mostly controlling their wealth independently.
2. The target consumers consist of people who defy traditions and take risks while they reject established norms but appreciate premium luxury.

Market Insight:

Rolls Royce recognized rising young customers who avoided typical luxurious tastes and instead embraced dynamic prestige through customization. Their dynamic way of living inspired them to seek cars that perfectly matched their appealing personality.

SWOT Analysis

Strengths: Iconic brand, unmatched craftsmanship, strong heritage.

Weakness: Faced criticism from new-generation consumers who see its image as old-fashioned yet formal.

Opportunities: Younger billionaires tapped into the market along with the growth of customized luxury while people show greater interest in self-expression.

Threats: Increasing competition from edgy luxury car brands like Tesla, Aston Martin, and Lamborghini.

Strategic Planning and Key Messages

Black Badge exists exclusively for people who maintain their own direction by breaking conventional standards. The brand presents Rolls Royce as a symbol of both

elegance and youthful rebellion which gives power to modern individuals breaking societal boundaries.

Tone: Rebellious, mysterious, and confident.

Media and Communication Channels

1. Luxury lifestyle magazines (Robb Report, GQ, Vogue)
2. Social media marketing (Instagram, YouTube, Facebook)
3. Influencer collaborations (young billionaires, artists, athletes)
4. High-end events & experiential marketing (private Black Badge previews)
5. Short films & cinematic video content (for e.g. “Black Badge – Rules Rewritten”)

Campaign Tactics and Creativity

1. The Black Badge car launch from Rolls Royce took place in atmospheric cities through engaging narrative sequences.
2. Rolls Royce introduced the “antihero” buyer profile as an unregretful self-made individual with strong ambition.
3. The Black Badge line received personalized customization through the addition of carbon fiber and blacked out trims and “infinity” logos for unique design options.
4. Rolls Royce developed exclusive VIP test drive programs together with private product launch events that took place in major global locations including London, Shanghai, and Dubai.

Timeline and Phased Rollout

1. During March 2016 Rolls Royce introduced Black Badge to the public at the Geneva Motor Show.

2. 2016–2017: Targeted PR in luxury circles and auto shows.
3. The company expanded globally in 2018–2021 through regional events in addition to using influencers while creating brand films for audiences.
4. New Black Badge models receive regular releases together with their standard versions including the Black Badge Cullinan and Black Badge Ghost.

Evaluation Metrics and Results

1. Rolls Royce successfully acquired buyers who were much younger than the original demographic (average age from 56 to 43).
2. Black Badge models constitute more than 27% of the total sales at Rolls-Royce worldwide.
3. Positive coverage in Forbes, GQ, Business Insider, and major luxury/lifestyle publications.
4. The fashion brand achieved better social media interaction while becoming more important to younger ultrahigh-net-worth individuals. This change triggered the establishment of various personalized options across the entire company.

Impact and Legacy

1. The Rolls Royce brand shifted to present itself as an advanced yet fearless luxury label.
2. The design motivated multiple manufacturers to release their alternative dark performance editions such as Bentley's "Blackline".
3. The company developed a model that defines successful changes for heritage brands while maintaining their original character.

4. The rebranding efforts of Rolls-Royce resulted in their most successful year of sales throughout their history.

Data Chart

BODY TYPE	LENGTH	WEIGHT	ENGINE TYPE	ENGINE SIZE	CYLINDERS	POWER	TORQUE	ACCELERATION
4 door fixed-head coupé with 2+2 seats	5285 mm	2440 kg	turbocharged petrol	6.6 litre	12, V	633 PS / 624 bhp / 465 kW @ 5600 rpm	870 Nm / 642 ft.lb / 88.7 kgm @ 1700-4500 rpm	0-60 mph 4.3 s
ACCELERATION	TOP SPEED	ECONOMY	CO. EMISSIONS					
0-100 km/h 4.5 s	250 km/h / 155 mph	22.2/10.1/14.6 l/100km urban/extra-urban/combined	333.0 CO ₂ g/km					

Recommendations for the Campaign

Increase Owner Narratives in Digital Storytelling:

To personalize the brand and demonstrate how it fits with bold, modern lifestyles, feature actual Black Badge owners in short form movies or Instagram Reels, particularly young, diverse business owners.

Promote Luxury Content Created by Users:

Encourage well-known users to discreetly disclose exclusive Black Badge features online in order to create natural buzz.

References:

1. <https://www.vogue.co.uk/arts-and-lifestyle/article/rolls-royce-black-badge-ghost-review>
2. <https://www.gq-magazine.co.uk/lifestyle/article/rolls-royce-cullinan-black-badge>
3. <https://robbreport.com/motors/cars/gallery/photos-powerful-rolls-royce-black-badge-spec-tre-1236222606/16x9/>
4. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=33EQripwZKE>
5. <https://www.press.rolls-roycemotorcars.com/rolls-royce-motor-cars-pressclub/article/detail/T0351792EN/rolls-royce-black-badge:-the-origin-story?language=en>
6. <https://www.lovethecar.com/work-awards/campaigns/black-badge-39769> 7. <https://www.carfolio.com/rolls-royce-wraith-black-badge-490732>

Learnings and Outcomes (Self-reflection):

- I learned the importance of repositioning a brand.
- I learned how audience research influences PR strategy.
- I learned how different communication channels work together.
- The campaign demonstrated how social media, luxury publications, influencers, cinematic content, and exclusive events can work together to create a consistent brand experience.